

Droughtdancer

The patients are dancing for the next one, you know that, right? We can't know why. It's not something afforded to us. I've tried asking and I can never hear their responses. And when I do hear what they say, my mind can't make any sense of it. I'll play it over and over again in my head, like a tape. Nothing. Gibberish. The answer, then, is no. I ask them why and never understand, so their answer doesn't matter. It doesn't matter what they're saying, because they know we aren't understanding. They might have actually answered the first time. After that? Might be telling me to go touch grass and mind my business for all I, for all we know. What gets me is the ringleader. She... it's like I'm observing from behind soundproof glass. I can watch all I want, am I the computer from 2001? Ringleader certainly isn't. She doesn't give a fuck what I do. Nothing like my concern for her. Do I care for her, or am I compelled to, for money, my salary? They talk about transubstantiation at church, but the only transmuter in this epoch is money. Boat? Trade in some money and you've got one. Food, water, family? Money. Poor, homeless? No dice. Magic is a privilege in this world. It's not just bottom-up either. Want to influence large swaths of humanity? Slap a high salary on it. That'll incentivize your bundle of behaviors quite nicely. Transmute and reduce humanity into tasks and behaviors. There's the mechanistic school of psychology. Why not the mechanistic school of salary. But yes, not everyone is permitted to log into the internet and transmute labor into a box of build-your-own dinner. For those who want to buy idiot-proof hobby-work. Because the type of cooking without guardrails can waste time, can waste preciousness. A whole evening, even. Why not sell boutique experiences, too. Microwave meals aren't for everyone, after all. Some people want a build-a-bear they can *eat*. Are we all the computer from 2001? Did we start that way or did years of criteria-mediated work make us this way? How do the dancers mute themselves. And why. Sometimes they tap their chests and we can hear them again. Tap on, tap off. I suppose from their perspective it's "tap off, tap on": we aren't their center. They are their own center. They change rooms too. One of the dancers tapped their chest to explain that the new rooms have numbers of significance to the people who choose them. I rolled my eyes; they tapped off and walked away to greet another dancer with a flood of gibberish. I didn't need to understand the gibberish this time. I knew what they were talking about. I couldn't help it though: if every patient got to pick their own room, nothing would get done. Yet the dancers and the other patients all changed rooms like clockwork when it was time to. They made it work, was my understanding. I guessed it was a comfort thing. Then it hit me. Money, church, things, transmutation, picking a room that resonates with you or your life or both. Symbolic comfort. People file documents in the direction of the IRS every year. Why is it so strange to pick a room of significance at the outset instead of warping your life around some new randomized and hollow number that was forced on you? You can ascribe life-side meaning to your hospital stay if you choose the same number as the room of your birth, for example. You can wake up every day at the funny farm knowing that it will be transmuted into

a day of renewal, of tears, of joy. By choosing. Another tap of the chest and this one began explaining he chose Room 157 because his calendrical system, the one nestled in his heart, subtracts the Age of Enlightenment's duration from the current year. He used Wikipedia as his source. Another face. This one didn't end the interaction though, or go tell his friends about it. He was curious. Said it didn't matter how inaccurate or, for that matter, accurate, it was of an estimate. Went on to say he chose the start and endpoint based on the "I think, therefore I am" of Descartes and the freeing of Bicetre by Philippe Pinel in 1794 Paris. He laughed. Said, "Don't worry, we will free you too. Just let us work. We watch you back. We are working on one of yours now. He has a long way to go." One of the dancers tapped the speaker's chest for him, while he was looking at me. I still heard what he said, understood the entire utterance.

I tapped my heart and could smell the water from the garden hose of my childhood.

He smiled back.